

DWF

Complete firm and application research — practice areas, apprenticeship structure, skills sought, culture, sustainability & ESG, regulatory context, a recent deal, and personal application notes.

- Model:** Global provider of integrated legal and business services
- Practice areas:** 8 key areas — real estate, finance & restructuring, corporate, dispute resolution, tax & private capital, employment & pensions
- Apprentice track record:** "Trailblazer Group" — first 4 qualified solicitors, all 4 retained
- Rotations:** Every 12 months; every 6 months alongside trainees in the final 2 years

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1. Firm Overview

- DWF describes itself as a global provider of integrated legal and business services — combining legal services, legal operations, and business services in one offering
- Organised around eight key practice areas: real estate, finance & restructuring, corporate, dispute resolution, tax & private capital, and employment & pensions
- The apprenticeship programme is still young — its first cohort (the "Trailblazer Group") produced 4 qualified solicitors, all of whom were retained by the firm, seen as a sign of long-term commitment to the route

2. Practice Areas — Corporate

A practical approach to corporate law issues. The Corporate team advises on:

- Private equity transactions, for both institutions and management teams
- Public and private mergers and acquisitions
- Equity capital markets — IPOs on AIM and the Main Market, and secondary fundraisings
- Venture capital and growth capital
- Corporate governance and compliance, including shareholder agreements, partnership transactions and joint ventures

3. Technology, Media & Communications

- Helps clients exploit their IP portfolio, mitigate infringement risks, and maximise returns on IP rights
- Focuses on protecting and capturing value from intangible assets — technologies, brands, products, or data services
- Supports businesses to embrace change and efficiency in a fast-moving sector
- Getting content right is treated as crucial to avoid reputational damage, complex disputes, or regulatory fines
- Described as a dynamic sector with ever-growing client needs, combining legal expertise directly with media-sector knowledge
- Core areas: advertising, brands, content regulation, online harm, data protection, and intellectual property

4. Insurance Work — Notable Context

- Relevant to the Insurance Act 2015 and the importance of precise policy definitions (illustrated by a Saudi Arabia-related example) — a market-standard definition does not automatically mean a perfect one
- Covers insurance exclusions and consent-to-settlement provisions

5. Apprenticeship Structure

- Apprentices rotate around different departments and teams every 12 months
- In the final two years of the programme, rotations happen every 6 months, alongside trainee solicitors
- The first cohort — the "Trailblazer Group" — produced 4 qualified solicitors, with 100% retention

Example day-to-day tasks

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|--|---|
| • Assisting solicitors with casework and legal research — <i>proactivity, quick learning</i> | • Keeping client files organised — <i>organisation</i> |
| • Drafting legal documents and correspondence — <i>formality</i> | • Client meetings and court proceedings — <i>professionalism</i> ; helping the team function smoothly — <i>teamwork</i> |

6. Skills Sought

- Effective questioning and active listening
- Ability to find, analyse and assess documents
- Recording and presenting information accurately and clearly
- Assessing the relevance of different sources of law
- Recognising when legal research is needed, and using appropriate methods
- Developing strategies and solutions grounded in a genuine understanding of a client's commercial and personal circumstances — their needs, objectives, priorities and constraints
- Drafting documents from scratch, and using precedent to address all legal and factual issues
- Effective spoken and written advocacy, in and outside formal court hearings
- Assessing, communicating and managing risk, and bringing a transaction or case to a conclusion

7. Culture & Values

- Actively supports the integration of new people into the firm
- **Always Aim Higher** — consistently going beyond what's expected
- **Be Better Together** — collaboration as a core working principle
- **Disrupt to Progress** — embracing change and new ways of working to improve performance and reputation
- **Keep All Promises** — built on trust, loyalty and credibility
- **Attend to Details** — complex problems are approached through simple, effective solutions
- Strong focus on wellbeing, including a "This is Me" initiative covering menopause networks, a men-at-work network, and family support
- The **DWF Foundation** is the firm's charitable arm
- **DWF Link** — a networking group aiming to connect like-minded people through webinars, networking and volunteering activities relevant to future leaders, including tours, walks, networking events and talks
- A firm-run club supports work-life balance alongside the demands of the role

8. Sustainability & ESG

- Sustainability is embedded directly into firm decision-making, guided by a materiality assessment identifying which ESG issues matter most to stakeholders
- Focus areas: climate action, diversity, empowering colleagues, supporting clients, and trust and transparency
- Target: net zero by 2045; reduce emissions by 50% by 2030
- **DWF Forest** — a carbon removal and biodiversity initiative
- Diversity & Inclusion target: increasing female representation on the executive board to 40% by 2025
- Inclusive policies and internal networks cover areas including menopause and disability
- Achieved an EcoVadis silver medal, placing the firm in the top 25% of companies assessed
- Progress metrics are refreshed every two years to demonstrate real, ongoing progress rather than a one-off assessment

9. Consumer Duty — Regulatory Context

Relevant regulatory background for client work, particularly in retail, food and hospitality: the Consumer Duty places additional responsibilities on firms, including approving plans to rectify poor customer outcomes and completing annual assessments of outcomes for customers.

- A core requirement to deliver good outcomes for retail customers
- Cross-cutting rules setting behavioural expectations
- Four specific outcome-focused rules

Compliance work here is about minimising client risk while maintaining broader commercial awareness of the pressures driving the regulation.

10. Recent Deal

DWF advised Gemfields Group Limited on the sale of Fabergé Limited, the iconic luxury brand, for \$50 million.

11. Application Themes

General themes covered by DWF's apprenticeship application, rather than exact question wording (omitted by request).

- **Work experience:** the application asks for a full picture of relevant experience — virtual and in-person, legal and non-legal — including insight programmes, volunteering, and any direct shadowing or networking events attended
- **Motivation for a solicitor career at DWF:** covers why law generally, and why DWF specifically — a chance to connect academic interests (e.g. law and business) with practical experience and the firm's particular sector strengths (e.g. IT, Media & Communications) and seat-rotation structure
- **Demonstrating a core firm value:** candidates are asked to evidence a time they've demonstrated one of DWF's stated values (e.g. Always Aim Higher) in their own life, and explain how they'd apply that value in the apprentice role itself
- **Commercial awareness:** candidates are asked to discuss a current commercial awareness trend or news topic of genuine personal interest, and explain its relevance to DWF specifically — strong answers tend to link the trend to something DWF is visibly already doing (e.g. its sustainability commitments)

Since the exact live application questions and portal link have been left out of this pack by request, always check the current application form directly for exact wording, structure and word limits before writing final answers.

12. Personal Fit Notes

Drafted talking points connecting personal motivations and experience to the firm's positioning — for use/refinement in application answers, written at a general thematic level.

- DWF's integration of legal and business services mirrors a personal academic combination of law and business studies, alongside practical marketing experience — a natural fit for firms that don't treat law as operating in isolation from commercial strategy
 - A particular pull toward IT, Media and Communications law, driven by a creative/marketing background alongside academic strength in law — seat rotations are appealing precisely because a single specialism hasn't yet been settled on
 - DWF's full retention of its first apprentice cohort is read as a genuine signal of long-term investment in apprentices, which matters for anyone looking for a firm to grow with over time
 - Marketing leadership, business analysis (e.g. SWOT-style thinking), and school representation/tours are all used as transferable evidence of understanding client needs, crafting strategy, and delivering outcomes with empathy and precision — directly relevant to DWF's client-centred approach
 - DWF Link and firm-run wellness clubs are seen as supporting a sustainable work-life balance alongside a demanding role
 - Volunteering experience (e.g. supporting younger students) is linked personally to the ethos behind the DWF Foundation
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Sources: dwf.law sector and careers pages; firm sustainability and ESG reporting; firm press coverage. Compiled as private research — specific live application questions have been omitted by request; always verify current salary, deadline, and exact application wording against the live listing before applying.